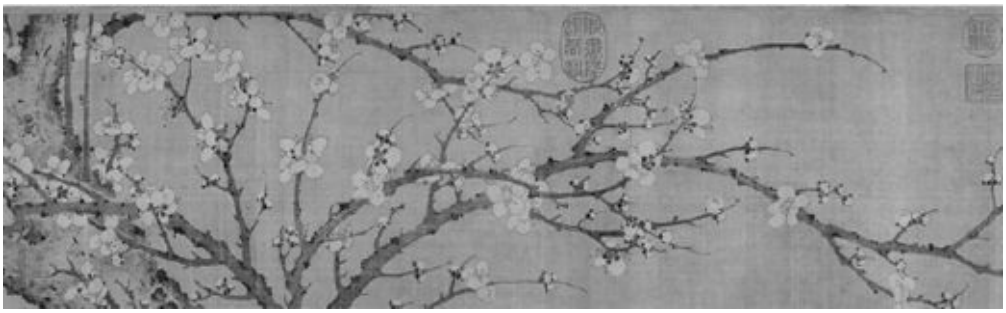
protesting, they searched for a new kind of peace with the status quo.

Traditional Confucianism had directed its followers towards the orderly performance of duties and rituals as the path to virtue: “It is by the rules of propriety that the character is established,” Confucius himself was reported to have said. Confucian academies taught the rules of order, the duties of each man in his place and station, the importance of ceremony. They had long been used to train and prepare state officials, and as a tool for statecraft, Confucianism had never progressed very far in tackling more abstract ideas.*



8.1 Ink Plum Blossoms, *by Wang Yansou of the Song dynasty.* Credit: © Smithsonian, Freer Gallery of Art and Arthur M. Sackler Gallery

Now the philosopher Zhu Xi began to transform Confucianism from a tool of the impotent state into a philosophy for every man. He brought to Confucianism a consideration of ultimate reality; he taught and spoke of the relationship between the *essence* of material things (the *li*) and their physical existence (the *qi*). *Li* in itself does not have form that can be touched; *qi* gives shape to *li*, but at the same time obscures it. The essence, the *li*, of every human being is essentially good; that goodness shines through when the *qi* is refined, polished, brought to the place where it is transparent. And that polishing and refinement is achieved not by faithful service to the government but through private contemplation and individual education: in Zhu Xi’s own phrases, “quiet sitting” and “pursuing inquiry and study.”[5]

“Start with an open mind,” the sage told a student who was struggling to find the truth, “then read one theory. Read one view before reading another. After you have read them again and again, what is right and wrong, useful